Yes, No, Maybe Later

Civic Skill: Voice & Participation | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 3 (Wellbeing) & Outcome 1 (Identity) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will practise recognising and expressing assent and dissent — agreeing, disagreeing, or wanting to pause — understanding that participation is always a choice, never an obligation.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can show or say 'yes,' 'no,' or 'not right now.'
- I can notice when a friend is signalling they want to stop.
- I can accept someone else's 'no' without being upset.

MATERIALS

- Green, red, and yellow cards or ribbons (yes / no / maybe-later signals) for each child
- A set of simple illustrated scenario cards (e.g., 'Do you want a turn on the swing?', 'Do you want to join our game?', 'Can I have a hug goodbye?')

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. OPENING (3 min): Introduce the three signal cards — green (yes), red (no), yellow (maybe later / not sure). Practise showing each one.

2. PRACTICE ROUND (5 min): Educator asks simple questions ('Do you want to stand up? Sit down? Clap?') and children respond using a signal.

3. SCENARIO CARDS IN PAIRS (8 min): In pairs, one child reads or is shown a scenario question, and their partner responds with a signal card. The asker must accept the answer respectfully and say 'okay' — no persuading.

4. GROUP DISCUSSION (7 min): 'How did it feel to say no and have it accepted? How did it feel to hear no and accept it?' Validate that both feelings are real.

5. CONNECT TO REAL LIFE (2 min): 'This is true here too — you always get to choose whether to join in an activity, and that's okay.'

EXTENSIONS

- Keep the signal cards available for children to use during real activities across the week
- Extend to group games — practise stopping a game the moment someone shows a red card
- Discuss with children what to do if someone's 'no' isn't being noticed by a peer

ASSESSMENT

- Observe whether children accept a 'no' without pushing or arguing
- Note children's confidence in signalling their own preference, including reluctant participants
- Key question to ask individually: 'What do you do when a friend says no?'

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Are there moments in your daily routine where a child's 'no' currently isn't fully respected? What could change?
- Which children found it hardest to accept another's 'no'? What might that reveal?
- How will you keep participation genuinely voluntary in the sessions that follow this program?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 3 (Wellbeing) & Outcome 1 (Identity). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.